

Chapter 8

Yin Lingzhu didn't speak further. She quietly looked at Ji Jingrong's room, envy appearing in her eyes.

Ji Jingrong's room had basically remained the same, still filled with cute dolls everywhere, and even the essential items for daily life were decorated with cat and dog stickers.

Compared to Ji Jingrong's room, Yin Lingzhu's apartment looked like it had just been renovated, without any signs of life.

The only place with any atmosphere of living was the kitchen that Yin Lingzhu had been using constantly.

"Are you still going to cook for her tonight?" Just as Yin Lingzhu was thinking about the kitchen, she heard Ji Jingrong ask her.

"Mm, she might come back tonight." Yin Lingzhu nodded.

Ji Jingrong looked at her with disappointment¹, unable to help but complain. "In this past year, how many meals have you cooked for her, but how many times has she actually eaten them?"

"How many times has she come back?"

Yin Lingzhu listened quietly, silently answering in her heart: ten times.

"Forget it. Your birthday is coming up in a few days. What gift would you like?" Ji Jingrong saw Yin Lingzhu's lowered head and couldn't help but soften her voice as she asked.

Yin Lingzhu shook her head and picked up Tiantian, who was curled up beside her legs. "I don't know either."

Having been here for so long, the only thing she wanted was Yan Si.

"On your birthday, your company happens to be holding a concert, and they're still recruiting singers. You could participate." Ji Jingrong's expression was excited.

She picked up her phone to check, wanting to see if she had remembered correctly.

"Don't you like being on stage?" Ji Jingrong's hands didn't slow down while she continued persuading with her words.

Yin Lingzhu's movement of petting the cat paused. "How do you know that?"

She shouldn't have mentioned that she liked the stage.

Ji Jingrong was still looking for that message. "I went to see your performance. At that time, the light in your eyes was more dazzling than the stage itself."

Realizing what she had said, Ji Jingrong's finger paused, and she couldn't help but sneak a glance at Yin Lingzhu.

Yin Lingzhu was currently immersed in memories and didn't notice Ji Jingrong's action.

She had indeed participated in a concert once - a very small one.

She and four others formed a team. The five of them sang energetically on stage while the audience below numbered less than fifty people.

Yin Lingzhu had originally gone to complete a company task, but while she was singing, someone in the audience suddenly shouted loudly: "Bamboo²!!"

After repeatedly confirming, Yin Lingzhu was sure this voice was calling her.

She could see that person shouting energetically on stage, holding her light stick in their hands.

She didn't know what happened, but she seemed to be infected by the girl and sang even more energetically, immersing herself completely in the stage.

After the concert ended, Yin Lingzhu specifically sought out that girl.

When facing her, the girl's entire face turned red, and she couldn't even speak properly. Excitedly, she said one sentence:

"I—I will always support you!"

The girl ran away after saying this.

It was at that moment that Yin Lingzhu fell in love with the stage. She had never performed on stage before, so she had never experienced this feeling.

That feeling of having someone love you wholeheartedly and unreservedly.

But afterward, she never got on stage again.

She thought she no longer cared, but today, when Ji Jingrong brought it up, she realized she still did care.

"That concert was so small, how did you know about it?" Yin Lingzhu finished her reminiscing and remembered this question.

Ji Jingrong had already prepared her response. "As your friend, of course I had to support you."

When Ji Jingrong said this, her expression was completely natural, but only she knew how unnatural the word "friend" felt coming out of her mouth.

"I still won't participate in this concert." Although Yin Lingzhu was tempted, she still refused when she spoke.

Before Ji Jingrong could express her confusion, Yin Lingzhu spoke first.

"On my birthday, she might come." Yin Lingzhu's tone was full of uncertainty and a little hope.

Ji Jingrong looked at her quietly without speaking, her eyes hiding heartache.

It was already evening now. The lights in the room were turned on, and the bright light shone on Yin Lingzhu, but it couldn't dispel her current loneliness.

"It's getting late. I should go cook." Yin Lingzhu held the cat in her arms and stood up.

Yin Lingzhu walked to the door and smiled slightly at Ji Jingrong. "Thank you for teaching me cooking these past few months."

Ji Jingrong only had time to say "You're welcome" before she saw Yin Lingzhu's somewhat thin silhouette disappear behind the door.

Only then did she dare to completely release her hidden emotions.

Ji Jingrong's eyes surged with adoration, but it was forcibly suppressed by its owner.

She knew that now was not the time - she was a married person.

Ji Jingrong also knew that soon, she would be able to pursue her openly.

She sat in the spot where Yin Lingzhu had just been, where Yin Lingzhu's scent still seemed to linger.

Yin Lingzhu returned to her room and gently put down Tiantian from her arms.

She refilled Tiantian's bowl with cat food, added some glucosamine³, then went to the kitchen to busy herself with tonight's dinner.

For Yan Si, she had practiced her cooking skills to perfection.

Before cooking, Yin Lingzhu sent a message to Yan Si.

While cooking, she kept her phone within her line of sight.

Yin Lingzhu served the finished dishes.

Throughout this entire process, there were no messages on her phone.

Yin Lingzhu looked through their chat history - the screen was full of green⁴, without a single white message.

She stared at Yan Si's chat background. The photo was one Yin Lingzhu had specifically chosen.

In the picture, Yan Si's eyes were gentle, the corners of her mouth curved upward, her hair held back with a shark clip⁵, wearing a khaki-colored trench coat, with the camera capturing her in profile.

Looking at that smile, Yin Lingzhu's heart unconsciously felt happy.

The next morning.

Yin Lingzhu came to Yan Si's company. This was the first time she had actively sought out Yan Si, and also the first time she had come to Yan Si's workplace.

As a top artist in the company, Yan Si had her own office.

Yin Lingzhu sat outside waiting.

She stared eagerly at that door, hoping Yan Si would finish her work quickly.

While she was anxiously waiting, a woman came out with obvious lip marks on her neck.

The woman wore a bright red long dress with big wavy golden hair. Combined with exquisite makeup that outlined her curvaceous figure, her entire being exuded a seductive aura.

The neckline of her dress was somewhat wrinkled, and although it had a slit from the thigh, the wrinkles at the hem of the dress were even more obvious.

Yin Lingzhu recognized her - a popular actress named Si Xin⁶ who had become famous from a modern drama.

But why would she come out of Yan Si's room?

While Yin Lingzhu was lost in thought, she keenly noticed Si Xin's gaze looking in her direction.

Before she could figure out the reason, she saw Yan Si also come out.

There was obvious lipstick on her lips, which clearly wasn't applied by herself.

It looked more like someone had kissed it on.

Yin Lingzhu was shocked by her own thoughts and couldn't quite believe it.

But her mind wouldn't obey her control. She couldn't help thinking of Si Xin who had just come out.

There were lip marks on her neck too, and they seemed to be the same color as the lipstick on Yan Si's lips.

Yin Lingzhu's mouth opened but stopped instantly. She didn't know what to say to Yan Si.

She had clearly thought everything through last night, but now her mind was completely blank.

Yan Si saw Yin Lingzhu and frowned. "How did you get here?"

"The day after tomorrow is my birthday. Could you please come home?" Yin Lingzhu spoke up.

"Mm, I understand. You can go back now." Yan Si nodded, her eyes showing no emotion.

She wore a black suit and looked very cold.

Looking at her, Yin Lingzhu felt a wave of sadness in her heart. She seemed unable to warm Yan Si's heart.

"If there's nothing else, you can leave." Yan Si's voice sounded again.

She treated Yin Lingzhu with an indescribable coldness, not like she was treating a wife, but like she was treating a stranger.

Yin Lingzhu actually had more questions she wanted to ask her.

Why did Si Xin come out of your office?

Why do you have the same lipstick color as her?

What's with the obvious wrinkles on her dress?

Yin Lingzhu wanted to ask Yan Si all these questions.

She stared into Yan Si's eyes, but those pupils seemed to have no trace of her existence.

Yin Lingzhu shook her head again and left the company in silence.

She actually had an answer to these questions in her heart, but she stubbornly refused to think about that answer.

Perhaps it was a coincidence - they happened to have the same lipstick shade, and Si Xin happened to leave home in a hurry today without straightening her dress properly.

On the way home, Yin Lingzhu's mind kept making excuses for Yan Si.

When she got home, she was still carrying the groceries she had bought, though she didn't even know when she had bought them.

Yin Lingzhu put the groceries in the kitchen and began looking for Tiantian around the apartment.

Tiantian was brought back by Yan Si one time when she came home.

Yan Si said she had bought it specifically for her.

From then on, Yin Lingzhu treasured the folded-ear cat, even learning to make cat food because of it.

Most of the time, Yin Lingzhu would personally cook for Tiantian. Only when it needed glucosamine would she give Tiantian cat food.

"Tiantian, come out quickly. Mommy has cat treats for you." Yin Lingzhu held cat treats in her hand, continuously making sounds to entice the little cat.

"Meow~~~" Tiantian made a cat sound.

Yin Lingzhu carefully identified the sound and found it was coming from Yan Si's bedroom.

Yan Si's bedroom.

She had only entered Yan Si's bedroom once - when she first marked Yan Si.

She hadn't gone in any other time, and she could sense that Yan Si didn't want her to enter.

Yin Lingzhu was in a dilemma for a moment.

Just when Yin Lingzhu didn't know what to do, Tiantian suddenly squeezed out through the door crack.

Yan Si hadn't locked the door.

"You little rascal, why are you so mischievous?" Yin Lingzhu quickly squeezed out a little bit of cat treat and placed it on her fingertip.

Tiantian's head nudged up and down, and Yin Lingzhu's heart was unconsciously melted.

The grievances Yin Lingzhu had suffered from Yan Si seemed to disappear at this moment.

During the time when Yan Si wasn't there, Tiantian gave Yin Lingzhu enough companionship and peace of mind.

"If only your other owner could stay with me like you do." Yin Lingzhu touched Tiantian's little head.

Seeing that Tiantian had finished licking the cat treat from her fingertip, she held it in her arms.

Tiantian's head moved close to Yin Lingzhu, vigorously rubbing against her arm.

Yin Lingzhu understood Tiantian's meaning and firmly refused. "You've finished all your cat treats for this week."

Tiantian seemed to understand her words and angrily turned its head away.

"I'll give you an extra meal this week. Tomorrow night I'll let you have cat treats again." Yin Lingzhu lowered her forehead and pressed it against Tiantian's little face.

Yin Lingzhu carefully held Tiantian and put it in the cat carrier, letting it adapt to the carrier environment.

Tiantian was timid and needed a long preparation time before going out, otherwise it would easily get stressed.

Tonight she would take Tiantian for a checkup. Hopefully everything would go smoothly.

Footnotes: ¹ "Disappointment" (恨铁不成钢) - A Chinese idiom literally meaning "to hate iron for not becoming steel," expressing frustration when someone you care about doesn't live up to their potential.

² Bamboo (竹子) - A cute nickname for Yin Lingzhu, since "竹" means bamboo in Chinese.

³ Glucosamine (软骨素) - A supplement commonly given to cats and dogs to support joint health, especially important for breeds prone to joint problems like Scottish Folds.

⁴ Green messages - In Chinese messaging apps, green typically indicates messages you've sent, while white/gray indicates received messages. So "full of green, without a single white" means she's been sending messages but getting no replies.

⁵ Shark clip (鲨鱼夹) - A type of hair clip shaped like a shark's mouth, popular for holding hair back.

⁶ Si Xin (司新) - The name of the actress character who appeared earlier in the story as someone connected to Yan Si.